

Bye Bye Carmack

John Carmack leaves iD software to work full time on the Oculus Rift
<http://dgit.in/jcarmack>

**Apple Kinect**

Apple buys PrimeSense – the company responsible for the sensors in the Xbox Kinect
<http://dgit.in/applekinected>

Tata Sky Everywhere TV

Dish TV did it in partnership with Ditto TV. And now, Tata Sky has launched a similar on-the-move Live TV service, the development of which has been in-house. The results are impressive

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Not long after Dish TV launched the Dish Online app that lets you watch Live TV on your smartphone or tablet, Tata Sky responded with its own Everywhere TV app. At the moment, this app is available only for iOS users, and the Android version will be hitting the Google Play Store soon.

Interface

Unlike Dish TV, for whom the Dish Online app was a completely new product, Tata Sky has added the Live TV feature to the existing Tata Sky app for iOS. And it's the same case for Android, via a simple app update. The focus has been on familiarity in terms of the interface – TV and tablet. Go to the Everywhere TV section, and you'll find the channel listing and program guide very similar to what you'll see with the Tata Sky DTH service on your TV. The channel icons simplify navigation because of the visual recognition rather than having to read text. The overall blue theme, with different elements blending in, looks very sophisticated.

TV viewing experience

This is the main point of the entire exercise, and we're very happy to report that the experience is extremely good. The quality of streaming offered by Everywhere TV is comparatively better than Dish Online. The three settings



for the amount of bandwidth you want the app to use makes all the difference in terms of streaming quality. At the highest quality setting, it's very similar to the quality offered by starsports.com, meaning it can be hooked up to a 46-inch TV and produce good picture quality. On the iPad, the streaming quality was superb. Playback never really gave any issues, except one time when we were flipping channels and the playback error showed up. A force close and restart of the app solved the problem.

There are currently around 50 channels on the platform, with more channels soon to be added. Not a bad start. However, some popular channels are missing – the Star Sports channels, for example – as are the HD channels. Agreed, there are bandwidth limitations when using the 3G and broadband connections in our country, but some of us have powerful broadband connections at home.

Data usage

Streaming on a Wi-Fi connection is smooth. Tap on a channel icon or a program name, and on an 8Mbps connection, it takes around 5 seconds to start playing, and another 2 seconds for the connectivity to stabilise and the picture quality to settle. In terms of bandwidth use, this app won't use more than 2 Mbps of your connection speed anyway, which means that on a 4Mbps or 8Mbps connection, you won't face a virtual network freeze for the other devices on the network. Also, the data usage that we clocked was in the region of 20 MB per hour while streaming, at the highest quality. This means that if you stream 2 hours regularly on a daily basis, you'll use 1.3 GB data per month, very much acceptable for most home broadband users. Toggle to lower quality, and the usage will be lesser. The scenario with 3G largely depends on

the signal strength and connectivity in the area.

Other services

Not just Live TV, the Everywhere TV service also offers Video on Demand and Catch Up TV. For video on demand, you can purchase a video from the library that Tata Sky offers, and download it to watch later on the iPad or iPhone. This content will be visible till the time you have the subscription to this service. Unfortunately, you can't yet purchase VoD content via the app, but when you do purchase a video via either the set top box or the online portal, it will show up in the queue of videos to be downloaded on the app.

Catch-Up TV offers certain previous episodes of certain programs on certain channels. You may be able to catch episodes of *Man vs. Wild* and *How Do They Do It?* – both shows of Discovery Channel for the last five days, but not the rest of the Discovery Network's shows.

Should you subscribe?

We think ₹60 per month is not a lot to spend on the flexibility and convenience offered by this service. It's a very good multi-screen alternative and very well solves the dilemma of having one TV at home, with two people wanting to watch different things. Sports lovers don't have to choose between a football match and an F1 race anymore! 